SECTION A
Reading Skills

20 marks

1. Read the following passage carefully : *10*

(1) Plastic pollution has become one of the most pressing environmental issues, as rapidly increasing production of disposable plastic products overwhelms the world's ability to deal with them. Plastic pollution is most visible in developing Asian and African nations, where garbage collection systems are often inefficient or nonexistent. But the developed world, especially in countries with low recycling rates, also has trouble properly collecting discarded plastics. Plastic trash has become so ubiquitous that it has prompted efforts to write a global treaty negotiated by the United Nations.

(2) Plastics made from fossil fuels are just over a century old. Production and development of thousands of new plastic products accelerated after World War II. It transformed the modern age so much that life without plastics is unrecognizable today. Plastics revolutionized medicine with life-saving devices, made space travel possible, lightened cars and jets — saving fuel and pollution — and saved lives with helmets, incubators, and equipment for clean drinking water.

(3) The conveniences plastics offer, however, led to a throw-away culture that reveals the material's dark side : today, single-use plastics account for 40 percent of the plastic produced every year. Many of these products, such as plastic bags and food wrappers, have a lifespan of mere minutes to hours, yet they may persist in the environment for hundreds of years.

(4) Most of the plastic trash in the oceans, Earth's last sink, flows from land. Trash is also carried to sea by major rivers, which act as conveyor belts, picking up more and more trash as they move downstream. Once at sea, much of the plastic trash remains in coastal waters. But once caught up in ocean currents, it can be transported around the world.

(5) Millions of animals are killed by plastics every year, from birds to fish to other marine organisms. Nearly 700 species, including endangered ones, are known to have been affected by plastics. Nearly every species of seabirds eats plastics. Most of the deaths of animals are caused by entanglement or starvation. Seals, whales, turtles, and other animals are strangled by abandoned fishing gear or discarded six-pack rings.

(6) The solution is to prevent plastic waste from entering rivers and seas in the first place, many scientists and conservationists — including the National Geographic Society — say. This could be accomplished with improved waste management systems and recycling, better product design that takes into account the short life of disposable packaging, and reduction in manufacturing of unnecessary single-use plastics.

Answer the following questions, based on the above passage :

(i) Which of the following statements best describes the reason why plastic pollution has become one of the most pressing environmental issues ? *1*

(A) Plastic trash collection systems have become inefficient or nonexistent.

(B) Rapidly increasing production of disposable plastic products overwhelms the world's ability to deal with them.

(C) Some plastics have a lifespan of mere minutes to hours, yet they may persist in the environment for hundreds of years.

(D) The developed world, especially in countries with low recycling rates, has trouble properly collecting plastics.

(ii) What is the tone of the writer in the given lines from paragraph 2 ? Rationalise your response in about 40 words.

'It transformed the modern age so much that life without plastics is unrecognizable today.' *2*

(iii) The passage includes some words that are opposites of each other. From the sets (A) – (E) below, identify two sets of synonyms. *1*

(A) garbage and trash

(B) starvation and strangled

(C) disposable and reduction

(D) persist and downstream

(E) transformed and revolutionized

(iv) Complete the sentence appropriately : *1*

The writer says that most of the plastic trash is found in the Earth's last sink and the reason it is transported around the world is _____.

(v) Based on the reading of the passage, examine, in about 40 words, the downside of the convenience that plastic offers. *2*

(vi) Complete the sentence appropriately : *1*

According to conservationists, the two ways in which most of the deaths of animals are caused are _____.

(vii) Based on the passage, how can we contribute to the reduction of plastic waste ? *1*

(A) by internationalising the waste management system

(B) by minimizing the use of single-use plastics

(C) by not abandoning fishing gear

(D) by not using helmets made of plastic

(viii) State one reason why plastic pollution is most visible in developing Asian and African nations. *1*